

Portions of the Travers Lacey Report were quite overstated, prompting the Calder of the Colonial Office to label the entire report "sensational and unbalanced" (C.O.525/160). The enquiry's section on the probable future effects of

Dr. Turner's comments were quoted in the 1935 Report of the Committee on Migrant Labour (Travers Lacey Report, see Nyasaland 1936), the first major study the subject in Malawi. Besides providing a great deal of information on the problem, it stimulated further enquiries. Although the writers of the report (among whom was W. H. Timcke; Levi Mumba was the secretary/interpreter) confessed that it was impossible to analyze all influences on village life individually, they still credited the bad ones to emigration.

The missionaries spoke in general terms about the bad effects of migration. Their claims were unsupported by data, and they seem to have expected African societies to remain unchanged under European impact. They looked at life from a very partial, European-centered vantage point. Many of them regarded all Africans as children incapable of making rational economic choices for themselves. They tended to blame every economic and social ill in the country on the labor exodus while ignoring the unsettling effects which internal migration and their own evangelizing activities might have on traditional life. Often the social and rural systems which African cultures had developed were misunderstood by Europeans.

Infidelity increased when men were away working, as Dr. W. Y. Turner of the Church of Scotland Mission pointed out. Besides lowering moral standards, and women spent unhappy lives alone in the village; the children conceived during fathers' infrequent stays at home grew up undisciplined.

In 1932 the Roman Catholic Church emphasized its objections to labor migration in an article by Bishop Guilleme published in Africa. He wrote that the of the family was the most serious consequence of emigration and the one to which Europeans paid the least attention. Men returned home for only two or three visits during their first ten years of married life. Women were incapable of earning enough money to support their households even when helped by the external family system. Despair replaced absent husbands in many rural homes.

On October 27, 1909, opposition to foreign recruiting was expressed at the Rev. Dr. Hetherwick and many others at a large public meeting held at Victoria Memorial Hall in Blantyre. The missionary joined a "sea of hands" supporting a resolution moved by the chairman of the gathering, Mr. F. W. B. "That this meeting of residents of Blantyre, planters, and others protests against the opening of the Protectorate to recruiting for the labour market of South Africa or elsewhere" (C.O.525/30).

Missionaries had an interest in maintaining a convenient pool of workers because several of the religious groups operated large estates and depended on coffee sales for financial support (F.O.2/669). In the 1880's, the Church of Scotland introduced coffee into Central Africa, and in 1900 it was grown on 900-acre farm, and on plantations operated by the Baptist Industrial Mission (Pheips-Stokes 1924). These churches and the planters shared economic interests when combined with Christian charity, they served to motivate missionary interest against emigration.